While co-opting influential defectors from other parties, the BJP focused equally on building networks of power with multiple regional parties in each state. Given that it was starting from a low base, the gambit of building a patchwork of alliances was smart strategy. This becomes clearer when you examine state-specific alliances by the BJP in each of the north-eastern states: in Assam with AGP and Bodoland People's Front (BPF) in its first government, and then AGP and United People's Party Liberal (UPPL) for its second term; in Manipur with NPP, NPF and Lok Janshakti Party (LJP); in Meghalaya with United Democratic Party (UDP), People's Democratic Front (PDF) and Hill State People's Democratic Party (HSPDP); and in Nagaland with NPP (see Table 16.3).

The model was to forge partnerships with regional parties that brought with them specific vote bases in order to build a wider social coalition. While the alliances in each state were different, so was the party's political messaging. The BJP's biggest disadvantage in the Northeast was the perception of being a Hindu/Hindi-focused outsider. It sought to offset this, state by state, by aligning with indigenous parties that represented large local interest groups. Tripura and Nagaland are two examples of this differentiated approach.

Table 16.3: The BJP's Coalitions in the Northeastern States (2016–2021)